

History of Lit





About the Course

Using Marshall's and Long's spines along with a variety of primary sources and additional readings, the History of Literature course introduces students to literary movements and figures in the 19th century. The course prioritizes influential texts in the English-speaking world but also seeks to give students glimpses at literary developments across the globe.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Literature: Grade 11, Literature: Grade 12, Literature: Grade 9, Literature: Grade 10



Placement & Combining Tips

Lessons are shared across high school grades with grade-specific assignments in the lesson plans as appropriate.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
9-12	History of Lit: Grades 9-12 1 time/week 30 min	American Literature English Literature for Boys and Girls History of Literature PDF

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Literature: Grade 9				
History of Lit: Grades 9-12 Poetry Study: Grade 9		General Lit.: Grades 9-10 Poetry Study: Grade 9	Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12	General Lit.: Grades 9-10 Plays: Grades 9-12 Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12
Literature: Grade 10				
History of Lit: Grades 9-12 Poetry Study: Grade 10 Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12		General Lit.: Grades 9-10 Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12	Poetry Study: Grade 10	General Lit.: Grades 9-10 Plays: Grades 9-12
Literature: Grade 11				
History of Lit: Grades 9-12 Poetry Study: Grade 11	Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12	General Lit.: Grades 11-12 Poetry Study: Grade 11	Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12	General Lit.: Grades 11-12 Plays: Grades 9-12
Literature: Grade 12				
History of Lit: Grades 9-12		General Lit.: Grades 11-12	Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12	General Lit.: Grades 11-12 Poetry Reading: Grades 9-12 Plays: Grades 9-12



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

☐ Print off the History of Literature PDF, as students will need to annotate and mark up various sections throughout the year.

☐ Although sources were condensed into one PDF when possible, there are still quite a few outside links due to the number of primary sources referenced, so make sure your student(s) has/have access to the internet for their course.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

History of Lit: Grades 9-12



American Literature



English Literature for Boys and Girls



History of Literature PDF



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

∞ [History of Literature PDF](#)

Related Course Quick Links

∞ [Foundations \(See Section 9: Literature\)](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



History of Lit: Grades 9-12

How To Approach



Read

The lesson plans will guide you through what to read over the terms. Take a moment before reading to remember where you left off last time.



Narrate

The lesson plans will give you specific instructions or tell you to choose a way to narrate that helps you interact with the ideas.



Discuss

The lesson plans will guide you with questions or instructions to share your ideas or what you are reading with others.



Teacher Note

These lessons are written directly to students, but to assist them throughout the year, please read through this section and the lesson plans so you are familiar with the instructions and flow of the lessons. Accountability components are occasionally added to facilitate teacher/student discussion and growing independence.

It is also valuable for those in a classroom setting to have a mix of lessons that students complete themselves silently and others read aloud and narrate together. Literature lessons lend themselves well to a larger discussion time at the end of the lesson where student can share their ideas.

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Term 1

WEEK 1 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 1

Introduction - Romanticism

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

What authors and books come to mind when you think about literature in 19th century? You may be familiar with terms such as the "Romantic period" or "Victorian period." Tell or jot down anything that comes to mind.

Over the year we'll learn about the lives and writings of people who wrote from about 1800-1900 AD. These individuals wrote in a wide array of genres: poetry, essays, short stories, plays, science fiction, mysteries, thrillers, children's stories, and more. When possible, the readings scheduled in History of Lit will align with what you are reading in your Poetry and General Literature courses.

We'll focus on authors who wrote in English but will also spend some time getting a taste for influential texts written in other languages as well. Every culture has significant texts and stories, so while we're limited in this course to English texts and texts translated into English, it's important to remember there is a world of books and literary traditions from cultures around the world which we don't have the time or often the language to read in this course!

English writings from the end of the 18th century into the first half of the 19th century are sometimes grouped together as part of the "Romantic Period." As with any generalization, this is a label scholars have put on the time frame as they look back, not something authors were so much thinking about consciously as they wrote, although as we will see, writers and poets from this period were often aware that their style of writing was something new.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

∞ PDF Link: History of Lit PDF "The Romantic Period" p.#-# (7 pages)

- What are some of the themes to look out for when you read literature from the Romantic Period? How did Romantic writers break with the traditions of Classicism? Do you recognize any ideas about poets and poetry in this reading that are still current today? How would you say our time is different or similar? What "rules" define literature written in English today?

WEEK 2 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 2

William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge

Materials: English Literature for Boys & Girls; History of Lit PDF

→ RECAP

What do you recall about the major themes of the Romantic Period from last week's reading?

→ INTRO

Today we will learn more about the life and work of two poets - William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge, who are most closely associated with English Romantic poetry.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. Marshall, Ch.LXXIV "Wordsworth - the Poet of Nature."

- How did Wordsworth's experiences as a child seem to influence his later poetry?

2. Marshall, Ch.LXXV "Wordsworth and Coleridge - the Lake Poets."

- What are some similarities and differences between the two poets?

• IMPORTANT DATES

William Wordsworth (1770-1850)

Samuel Taylor Coleridge (1772-1834)

First publication of the Lyrical Ballads (1798)

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 3 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 3

Rabindranath Tagore

→ INTRO

If you are taking the Poetry Reading course this year, you will spend much of Term 1 reading poems by the Bengali writer, philosopher and artist Rabindranath Tagore. He wrote in Bengali, but translated his own works into English. He is a significant figure for Indian nationalism, and, though not himself a politician, was a vocal proponent of India's independence at the turn of the twentieth century.

→ VIEW, NARRATE & DISCUSS

This video provides an excellent overview of Tagore's life and work. It will take nearly the entire lesson time to watch, although you can watch at 1.25x speed.

∞ Video Link: Rabindranath Tagore – Mystic Poet, Literary Genius & Nobel Laureate

- What were some of Tagore's major contributions to arts and history?

→ READ

∞ Link: The Gardener 85

This short poem is a timely piece to read, since Tagore was still alive and writing a century ago.

• IMPORTANT DATES

Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941)

WEEK 4 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 4

Sir Walter Scott

📄 Materials: English Literature for Boys & Girls

→ INTRO

E.M. Forster described Sir Walter Scott as a writer "over whom we shall violently divide," and certainly he has had his share of ardent readers and detractors. But one reason his works are still appreciated, as the literary critic Walter Allen said, is that "without being in the strict sense an historian, he revolutionized the writing of history." Today we will learn more about this author whom Virginia Woolf described as "perhaps the last novelist to practice the great, the Shakespearean art, of making people reveal themselves in speech," and of whom Jane Austen said, "Walter Scott has no business to write novels, especially good ones. It is not fair. He has Fame and Profit enough as a Poet"!

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.LXXVII "Scott - The Awakening of Romance

Ch.LXXVIII "Scott - 'The Wizard of the North'"

- What elements of Scott's subject matter and style seem distinctive to you?

→ READ

∞ Link: Lochinvar

WEEK 5 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 5

Percy Bysshe Shelley

📄 Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ RECAP

What do you recall about Sir Walter Scott from last week?

→ INTRO

Today, we are turning our attention to the first of two second-generation Romantic poets: Percy Bysshe Shelley, wife of Mary Shelley (the author of *Frankenstein*). If you are also taking the Poetry course, you will read some

• COMPOSITION -

Compare/Contrast

Compare and contrast what you read of Shelley's *Defence to the Preface to the Lyrical Ballads*.

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

of his poetry this week. However, today you will also read an excerpt from his Defence of Poetry, a philosophical essay on the nature and function of poets and poetry.

Do you recall any details about Shelley from the overview of the Romantic Period you read in Week 1?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. ∞ Article Link: Percy Bysshe Shelley Biography

2. Defence of Poetry

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF

- What are the main points Shelley is making in this excerpt? What images and arguments stand out to you the most? What do you think he means by "poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world?"

WEEK 6 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 6

Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley

→ RECAP

What do you recall about Percy Bysshe Shelley from last week?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

This article is fairly long. You may skim through the information about her early life with Percy Shelley, but be sure to read the excerpts of her travel writing and other prose towards the end of the article.

∞ Article Link: Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley Biography

- What aspects of Mary Shelley's character are evident in her writing? If you are reading Frankenstein this year, does knowing more about the author's life affect your reading of her work?

WEEK 7 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 7

John Keats

Materials: English Literature for Boys and Girls

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.LXXXI "Keats - The Poet of Beauty"

- What are some connections between Keats and other writers you have studied this term? Which excerpts of his writing did you enjoy the most in today's reading?

WEEK 8 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 8

Gertrudis Gómez de Avellaneda

→ INTRO

Today we will learn about a Romantic poet from another part of the world - Gertrudis Gómez de Avellaneda - who was born in Cuba and lived in Spain. She is the subject of The Lightning Dreamer, a biographical story told in poems, that you will begin to read this week if you are taking the Poetry Reading 9-12 course.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

∞ Article Link: Biography of Gertrudis Gomez de Avellaneda

- What aspects of her life made it difficult for her to be a poet? What aspects made it easier for her to be a poet than other women during this time period?
- The article describes her as "the epitome of the Romantic poet, the tragic heroine who rises to public acclaim yet, in private, is bitterly unhappy," which is a quotation from the preface to a 2001 edition of her

• EXTRA HELPING

Listen to a recitation of "To a Butterfly"

∞ Video Link: To A Butterfly by Gertrudis Gómez de Avellaneda

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

novel Sab. Are there other Romantic poets you've learn about so far this term that you would describe the same way?

- What questions do you have about Avellaneda's life and work?

→ READ & DISCUSS

∞ Link: 10 Poems by Gertrudis Gomez de Avellaneda

- What are your first impressions of her poetry? What subjects does she choose to write about?
- Do her poems remind you of anything else you've read?

WEEK 9 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 9

José María Heredia

→ RECAP

What do you remember about Gertrudis Gomez de Avellaneda's life and poetry?

→ INTRO

As a child in Cuba, Gertrudis Gomez de Avellaneda was tutored by the Cuban Romantic poet José María Heredia. Today we will learn more about him and read two selections of his poetry. If you are reading *The Lightning Dreamer*, you will discover just how much an influence Heredia had on Gertrudis Gomez de Avellaneda's development as a writer and thinker.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

∞ Article Link: Biography of José María Heredia

→ READ & DISCUSS

∞ Link: Niagara

∞ Link: The Hurricane

- How would you describe the mood of these poems?
- What does Niagara Falls and The Hurricane symbolize in these poems?
- Do these poems remind you of any others you have read this year?

WEEK 10 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 10

Felicia Dorothea Hemans

→ RECAP

Which of the two poems by Heredia that you read last week did you prefer?

→ INTRO

We're jumping back in time by a few decades today to meet Felicia Dorothea Hemans, an English Romantic poet who was wildly popular in her own day. She was read and admired by many poets you have been reading so far this term.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

∞ Article Link: Biography of Felicia Dorothea Hemans

- Writing allowed Hemans to provide for herself and her five sons after she was abandoned by her husband, but what were some ways that the challenges she faced negatively impacted her writing?
- Do you see any similarities in the biographies of Felicia Hemans and Mary Shelley?

→ READ & DISCUSS

∞ Link: To Wordsworth

∞ Link: The Haunted House

∞ Link: Casabianca

- How would you describe the style of these poems? Do they remind you

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Term 1

of other works you've read so far this year?

- The poem Casabianca, with its tragic pathos, was a poem that almost took on a life of its own upon publication, being often imitated and (later on) parodied. What do you think it was about this poem that made it so popular?

WEEK 11 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 11

Thomas Carlyle

Materials: English Literature for Boys & Girls

→ RECAP

What do you recall about the life and work of Felicia Hemans from last week?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.LXXXII "Carlyle - The Sage of Chelsea"

- Marshall writes that Carlyle "was a great historian, but in the history he gives us not dead facts, but living, breathing men and women. His pages are as full of color and of life as the pages of Shakespeare." What history books have you read that could be described that way? Why is it such a praiseworthy feature of history writing?
- What do you notice about Carlyle's style in the passages quoted in today's reading?

- COMPOSITION - Descriptive
Write a character sketch of Thomas Carlyle based on Marshall's chapter.

WEEK 12 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 12

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:
History of Lit. Readings

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

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Term 2

WEEK 1 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 13

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

For the next few weeks, we will meet a selection of American writers and poets who were active in the mid-to-late nineteenth century, around the years 1840-1876. As an introduction, Long has a helpful overview of the characteristics of the literature written during this period.

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF p.#-# "We have noted the significant fact" - "consider an age of poetry."

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. ∞ Article Link: Biography of Ralph Waldo Emerson

- Do you recognize some of the names of writer who influenced Emerson and who admired him in turn?

2. Spend some time exploring poems written by Emerson, or read excerpts from his famous essay "Self-Reliance" (you probably won't have time to read the whole thing during this lesson time, but you could come back to it later).

∞ Link: Poems by Emerson

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF #-#

- What does non-conformity mean to Emerson? How does he describe it?
- What does Emerson mean by "Trust thyself: every heart vibrates to that iron string"?
- How would you describe Emerson's language and imagery in "Self-Reliance"? What does it remind you of?

WEEK 2 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 14

Henry David Thoreau

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ RECAP

What stood out most to you reading about Emerson last week?

→ INTRO

Another Transcendentalist writer who was strongly influenced by Emerson was Henry David Thoreau. As you read today, see if you recognize similar themes and concepts from what you read last week.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. ∞ Article Link: Biography of Henry David Thoreau

2. "Solitude" from Walden

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF #-#

- How does Thoreau differentiate between being alone and loneliness? Why, according to him, can people be lonely even when they are with others?
- What does this reading tell us about how Thoreau relates to nature?
- Which aspects of Thoreau's views on solitude are most relevant today? Do you think that modern society still values solitude? What has perhaps made it harder to be alone in the way Thoreau describes?

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Term 2

WEEK 3 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 15

Henry David Thoreau, cont.

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ RECAP

What stood out most to you reading about Thoreau last week?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Today we will read another chapter from Thoreau's *Walden*. Read as much of it as you can in 20 minutes - if interested, you can always finish it another time. As you read, think about the care Thoreau takes with observation and attention to the natural world around you. How does it compare to other nature studies you have read in the past?

"Spring" from *Walden*

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF #-#

- What aspects of nature become symbolic to Thoreau? What do they represent to him?
- What message about life and renewal do you think Thoreau most wants readers to take from "Spring"?

WEEK 4 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 16

Walt Whitman

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

When Ralph Waldo Emerson first read Walt Whitman's collection *Leaves of Grass*, he wrote the following in a letter: "I find it the most extraordinary piece of wit and wisdom that America has yet contributed. I am very happy in reading it, as great power makes us happy. [. . .] I greet you at the beginning of a great career, which yet must have had a long foreground somewhere, for such a start. I rubbed my eyes a little, to see if this sunbeam were no illusion; but the solid sense of the book is a sober certainty. It has the best merits, namely, of fortifying and encouraging."

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. Whitman's Biography

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF #-#

- Which excerpts stood out to you the most? Which images were most striking or unusual?

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Walt Whitman Revolutionised American Poetry

→ IF YOU HAVE EXTRA TIME, YOU CAN LOOK UP AND READ SOME OF THE POEMS CITED IN TODAY'S READING, ALTHOUGH YOU WILL HAVE A CHANCE TO READ SOME OF WHITMAN'S POETRY THIS WEEK IN THE POETRY READING COURSE.

WEEK 5 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 17

Emily Dickinson

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

You may have read or heard Emily Dickinson's poetry before since many of her poems are anthologized for children, including "Hope is a Thing with Feathers" and "A Bird Came Down the Walk." However, behind their simplicity is often an enigmatic deeper meaning. Today we will learn more

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Term 2

about her life and work.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. Great Women Authors: Emily Dickinson

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF

- What were some of the major themes of Dickinson's work? How did her unconventional life influence her writing?

2. The Creative Years - a closer look at Dickinson correspondence with Higginson.

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF

You can read two of the more famous letters at the links below:

∞ Link: Dickinson Letter 260

∞ Link: Dickinson Letter 330

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Finding Emily Dickinson in the power of her poetry

WEEK 6 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 18

Catch-Up Day

→ CATCH UP

Use this time to catch up on lessons in this or another course, or explore Extra Helpings.

WEEK 7 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 19

The Victorian Period

📄 Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

The close of the Romantic Period is commonly marked by the death of Sir Walter Scott in 1832, and the remainder of the nineteenth-century in British Literature is referred to as the Victorian Period, named for Queen Victoria who reigned from 1837-1901. Literature written during this period often focused on social issues, the changes wrought by the Industrial Revolution, effects of new discoveries in science and a concern for morality. This was also the period that saw the rise in popularity of the novel.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

∞ PDF Link: History of Lit PDF "The Victorian Period" p.#-#

- Where do you see elements and concerns of the Victorian Period still present in our culture today?

WEEK 8 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 20

Charles Dickens

📄 Materials: English Literature for Boys & Girls

→ INTRO

You have likely already read a novel or two by Charles Dickens, but even if you haven't, characters like Scrooge and Oliver Twist, or lines such as "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times," have become familiar adages. Today you will learn more about his life and work

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.LXXXIV "Dickens - Smiles and Tears"

- What do you notice about Dickens style in the passages quoted here?

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Term 2

WEEK 9 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 21

WEEK 10 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 22

WEEK 11 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 23

Alfred Lord Tennyson

Materials: English Literature for Boys & Girls

→ INTRO

William Long writes of Tennyson: "Though the Victorian age is notable for the quality and variety of its prose works, its dominant figure for years was the poet Tennyson. He alone, of all that brilliant group of Victorian writers, seemed to speak not for himself but for his age and nation; and the nation, grown weary of Byronic rebellion, and finding its joy or sorrow expressed with almost faultless taste by one whose life was noble, gave to Tennyson a whole-souled allegiance such as few poets have ever won." And he goes on, "There is a wide variety in Tennyson's work : legend, romance, battle song, nature, classic and medieval heroes, problems of society, questions of science, the answer of faith,— almost everything that could interest an alert Victorian mind found some expression in his poetry." Today you will learn more about his life and work, and will read his well-known poem Ulysses, if you are taking the Poetry Reading course.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.LXXXV "Tennyson - The Poet of Friendship"

- What images and excerpts included in this chapter stood out to you?

WEEK 12 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 24

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

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Term 3

WEEK 1 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 25

Mark Twain

Materials: History of Lit PDF

→ INTRO

You many have already come across Mark Twain and his influence in other literature courses this year. The twentieth-century novelist Ernest Hemingway claimed that "All modern American literature comes from one book by Mark Twain called Huckleberry Finn." What do you already know about Mark Twain and what have you read?

Today we will learn more about Twain through his life, his influence worldwide, and through reading a short story.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. Twain's Biography

∞ Article Link: Biography - Mark Twain

∞ Video Link: Mark Twain - Writer

2. Twain's Influence

∞ Article Link: Mark Twain and World Literature

- Which examples cited in this article were most surprising to you?

3. "Luck" by Mark Twain

∞ Link: History of Lit PDF #-#

- Where do you find irony in this story? Was it what you expected it would be?

- How reliable is the clergyman as a storyteller?

WEEK 2 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 26

WEEK 3 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 27

WEEK 4 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 28

WEEK 5 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 29

WEEK 6 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 30

WEEK 7 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 31

WEEK 8 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 32

WEEK 9 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 33

WEEK 10 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 34

WEEK 11 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 35

WEEK 12 30m History of Lit: Grades 9-12 - Lesson 36

History of Lit: Grades 9-12

Examination

Term 1

· Discuss some of the defining authors and characteristics of the literature written in the first half of the 1800s that we've studied so far. Organize your thoughts into at least two paragraphs.

Term 2

· Describe some of the genres you've studied this term and tell about one particular piece or author you read about with more detail.